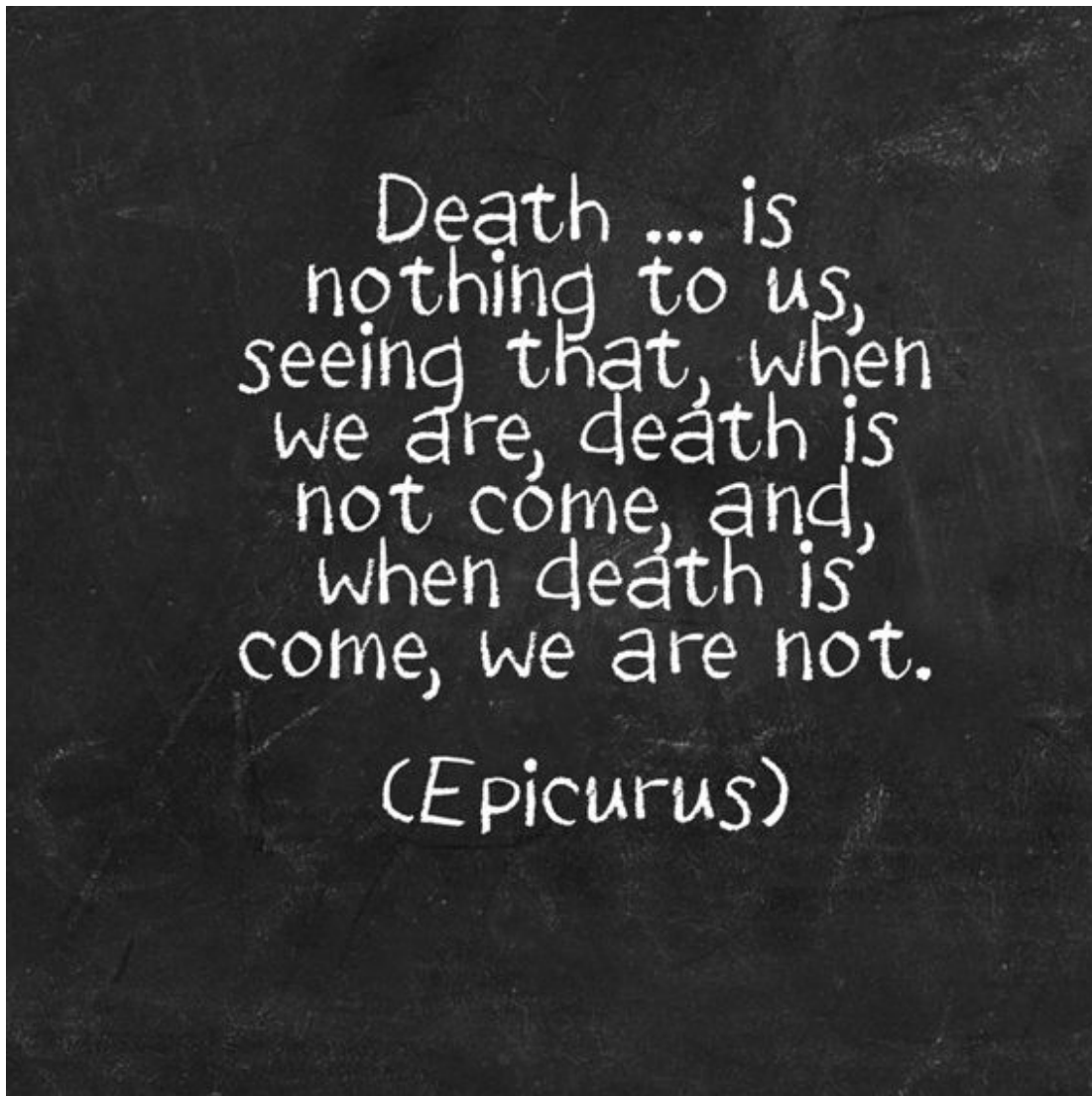


Epicureans



Despite the connotations of its name today, there was more to the Epicurean school of philosophy than simple hedonism. Although its founder Epicurus saw the 'good life' as the pursuit of fulfilment and happiness, he regarded the goal of life as peace of mind and freedom from fear – in particular, the preoccupying fear of death. Epicureanism was based on a belief that all matter, including our bodies, is composed of indestructible atoms. When we die, these are dispersed and re-form elsewhere; it is the end of our physical being and our consciousness, so is an end to both physical and emotional pain. Death, therefore, is nothing to be feared, and we should concentrate

on enjoying life rather than fearing a non-existent afterlife. Epicurus went further, questioning the relevance of gods, and even the existence of a benevolent god (although outright denial of the existence of god would have landed him in serious trouble). Inevitably, Epicureanism was quashed by later Christian and Islamic philosophies that followed, but many of its principles reappeared in modern scientific and liberal humanism.